



Timely strike: Axar Patel clean-bowled a dangerous-looking Tristan Stubbs (31, 21b) in the final after he missed an attempted sweep.

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bowling, and carried a positive mindset into my performances in the bilateral series (Australia T20Is, followed by the series against Afghanistan), which translated to success in the Indian Premier League.

I had a satisfying performance for Delhi Capitals, which boosted my confidence ahead of the T20 World Cup. It feels like life has come full circle as I was part of the tournament-winning team. I realised that you don't know what the Almighty has in store for you. *Shayad bhagwan mujhe World Cup-winning*

team mein rakhna chahte the (Perhaps God wanted me to be in the World Cup-winning team).

In the final against South Africa, you scored a crucial 47 off 31 balls while batting at No. 5. Earlier in the tournament, you batted at No. 4 against Pakistan, your preferred position. How did that experience help?

I have batted at No. 4 for my district, Kheda, and the Gujarat state team. So, I had a fair idea about how to pace the innings, having batted at that position in the IPL as well. When you bat with the security of a strong lower-middle order, you can play with more freedom than when batting at No. 7 or No. 8. In those positions, you need to take calculated risks.

When I was asked to bat at No. 4, I

knew I could take some time to settle down, and there wasn't a mad rush to hit every ball. I played to my strengths and targeted specific areas. If I knew I could play a shot to my strength, I would not hesitate to go for it. And when some deliveries were beyond my radar, I preferred to rotate the strike.

"When you have to play according to the situation, keeping a positive mindset is the key, and I just did that. The captain, Rohit Sharma, and the coach, Rahul Dravid, also backed me throughout the tournament. They told me, *"Tujhe slog nahi karna hai* (you don't need to slog); you just play your natural game..."

How do you handle tricky situations?

As a player, it's crucial to understand your game, but equally important is